the kind of focused professional the Congress lacked. An IITian, with a doctoral degree from the US, he had worked in Silicon Valley before he got a *bulawa* (call) to return to India. A long-time BJP supporter, he first approached the BJP leadership in 2010 with the idea of setting up a digital strategy for the party. 'I was able to convince the party that this was going to be a crucial piece in future elections,' he says. In July 2013, he formally set up the rather impressive sounding National Digital Operations Centre (NDOC) at the party's headquarters in Delhi with a single point agenda—how to use digital technology to help win the 2014 election. 'This wasn't a one-day affair—we went through many quarter-finals and semi-finals to get ourselves prepared for the big match,' is how he described the planning that went into the BJP's 'Mission 272-plus'.

Three things stood out from my conversation with Gupta. One was the constant urge for innovation among his team, some of it simple as much as it was brilliant. For example, his team created a 'missed call' system as early as in 2011—you give a missed call to a designated BJP number and a party worker would get back to you and feed you details of the Modi campaign or you could even volunteer to join it. The BJP got 1.3 million volunteers through this. Another dial-in number allowed you to listen to a Modi rally live.

Gupta even started Yuva TV, an Internet channel that would webcast the BJP's campaign. 'Our motto was—organize online for success offline,' says Gupta. The aim was to use technology to make Modi available to every Indian across every platform.

The second was the genuine team approach. Their leader may have been a fierce individualist when it came to his politics, but he had built a crack team when it came to technology. In Delhi, Gupta was supervising the NDOC which handled the BJP's Internet and mobile planning. But he was not alone.

One of the key members of the technology outreach was Mumbai-based Rajesh Jain, a successful Internet entrepreneur, who in 1999 had sold his Indiaworld.com venture for Rs 499 crore. Jain was running a mobile data solutions company, Netcom Solutions, when BJP treasurer Piyush Goyal